

RM01

Statement & Assumptions / Arguments / Conclusions / Courses of Action

About 4-6 marks in every RAS Prelims paper. Statement-Assumption, Statement-Argument, Statement-Conclusion and Statement-Course of Action have each appeared in every paper - 2021, 2023 and 2024 included. No calculation, no formula. Thirty to forty seconds an item is enough once the rules are drilled.

Four sub-types, one habit. Every RAS paper carries all four, and almost every wrong answer here comes from the same mistake: the student answers from what he knows about the world instead of from the words printed on the page. Break that habit and this chapter turns into four nearly free marks.

Statement-based Reasoning (4 sub-types)

Statement &

Assumption

- What the speaker TAKES FOR GRANTED
- Unstated but necessary for the statement to make sense
- Reject extremes: only, all, never, always
- Reject future effects and past causes

Statement & Argument

- Test = RELEVANCE + SIGNIFICANCE
- Yes/No does not decide strength
- Weak: tradition, imitation, emotion, ridicule
- Weak: 'it will not solve the problem fully'

Statement & Conclusion

- What MUST be true, not what is likely
- Test: statement true + conclusion false possible?
- Percentage is never a number
- Either-or when the two are complementary

Course of Action

- Test 1: is the problem real and stated?
- Test 2: would this action actually solve it?
- Must be practicable and within the agency's power
- Reject extreme, punitive and platitudinal actions

The common leak

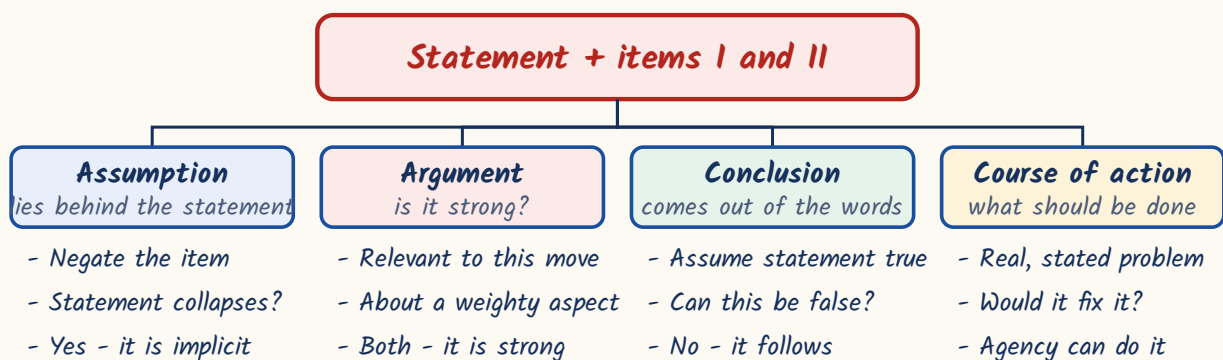
- Importing outside knowledge
- Extreme words in the option
- Option order gets reshuffled by RPSC
- Answering the topic instead of the statement

Four sub-types, one exam habit

All four sub-types look the same on the page. You are given a short Statement - a government decision, a notice, an advertisement, a news item. Below it come two items numbered I and II. Then a fixed question: are they implicit assumptions, are they strong arguments, do they logically follow as conclusions, or do they follow as courses of action. The options are always the same four shapes - I only, II only, Either or Neither, Both.

- **Statement & Assumption** - 'Which of the assumptions is/are implicit in the statement?'
- **Statement & Argument** - 'Which of the arguments is/are strong?'
- **Statement & Conclusion** - 'Which of the conclusions logically follows/follow?'
- **Statement & Course of Action** - 'Which of the courses of action logically follows/follow?'
- Each of the four appears in every RAS Prelims paper - plan for four items, not one.

The four sub-types and the test for each



Now the important part. These are the sub-types students get wrong most often, and the reason is not difficulty. It is that the student reads the topic - urea prices, coaching institutes, air pollution - and starts answering from general knowledge. The statement becomes a prompt for opinion instead of a closed piece of text. Every rule in this chapter exists to stop that.

TRAP

Do not import real-world knowledge. If the statement says all trains were cancelled, then no train ran - even if you personally saw one run. If a statement says a helpline exists, it works. You are being tested on reading, not on news.

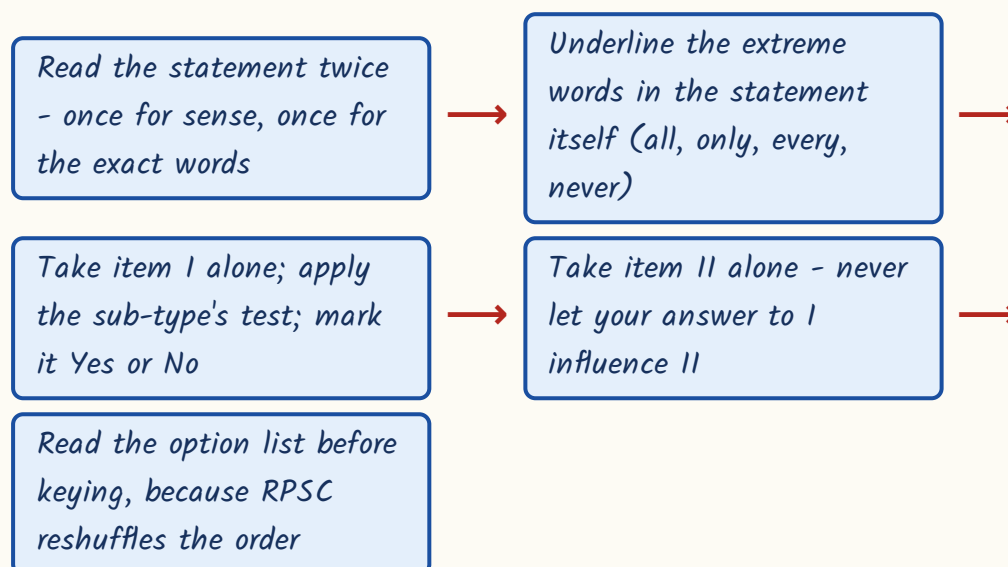
ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2024 asked the urea price-rise assumption item and the private-cars-in-the-CBD argument item; RAS Pre 2023 asked the literacy-rate conclusion item and the unfair-means course-of-action item; RAS Pre 2021 asked the extra-Sunday-classes assumption item and the beggars argument item. The pattern does not change - only the topic does.

The one rule that governs all four - read the statement as a closed world

Treat the statement as the only universe that exists. Nothing outside it is available to you - not your knowledge, not your opinion, not what usually happens. Whatever the sub-type, your question is the same: does this item live inside the statement, or does it come from outside? Assumptions live behind the statement. Conclusions live inside it. Arguments and courses of action are tested against it. Anything that comes from outside is out.

The four steps, same for every sub-type



Two separate verdicts, one option

Only I

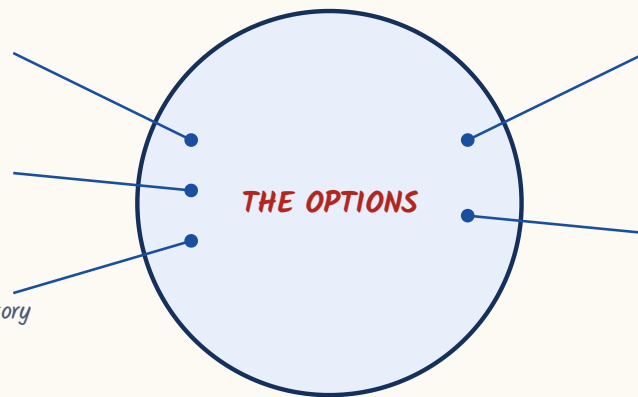
I passes, II fails

Both

each passes on its own

Either I or II

neither alone, but contradictory



Only II

II passes, I fails

Neither

both fail, and not a pair

- Extreme words in the ITEM - only, all, never, always, none, every, cannot - are almost always fatal.
- The one exception: the statement itself is that extreme, e.g. it says 'all trains were cancelled'.
- An item that merely restates the statement is never a valid assumption and never a fresh conclusion.
- A prediction about what people will do is never an assumption and rarely a conclusion.
- Comparisons the statement did not make - bigger, most, better than - are outside information.

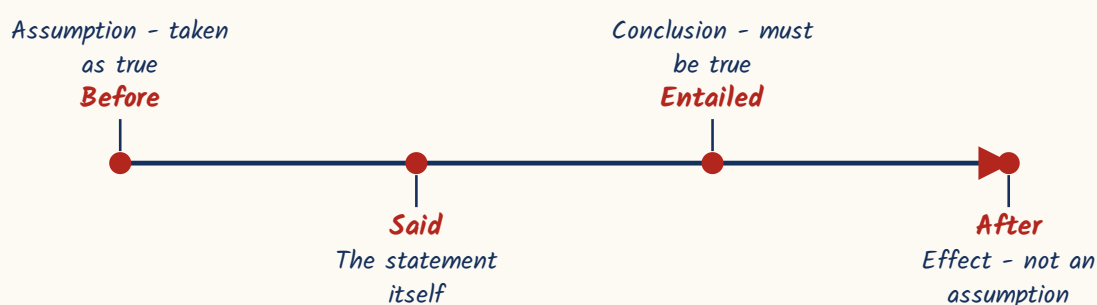
YAAD RAKHO

Remember the option order RPSC and SSC use: I only, II only, Either/Neither, Both. But papers do reshuffle it - so key the LETTER of the option you have chosen, not its position. Students lose marks by circling option (a) out of habit.

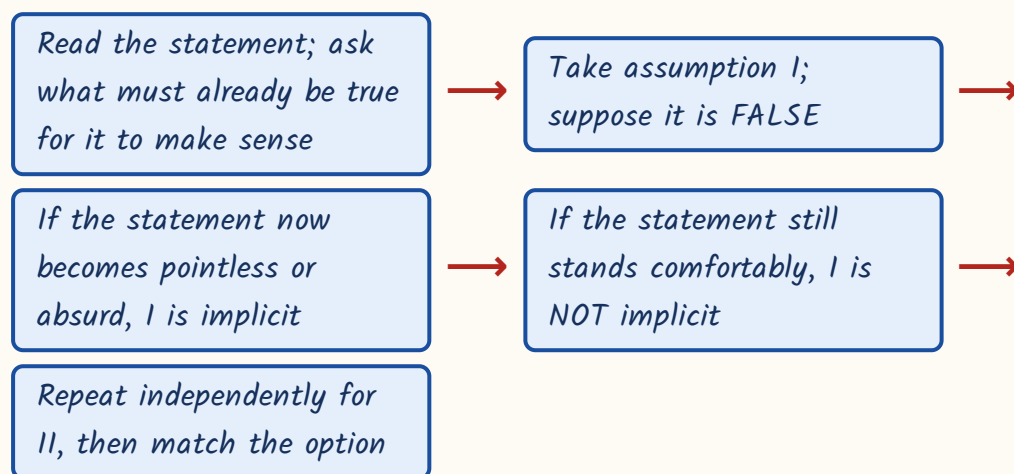
Statement & Assumption - what 'taken for granted' really means

An assumption is something the speaker or writer has taken for granted while making the statement. It is unstated, but the statement collapses into nonsense without it. That is the whole definition, and it is the golden rule of this sub-type: an assumption must be something the statement **TAKES FOR GRANTED** - not something that merely happens to be true in the world, not something desirable, not something that might follow later.

Assumption before, effect after



The necessity test - use it on every assumption item



- Reject any assumption carrying only, all, never, always, none, every, cannot.
- Reject a future EFFECT of the statement - an effect is never an assumption behind it.
- Reject a past CAUSE that the statement does not need, e.g. 'employees had gone on strike'.
- Reject an assumption that merely restates the statement - it adds no taken-for-granted idea.
- Reject comparisons about other people or places that the statement never touches.

Worked example - RAS Pre 2024. Statement: The government has decided to increase the price of urea with effect from next month. Assumption I: The government has the authority to fix the price of urea. Assumption II: Farmers will stop using urea from next month.

- Negate I - the government has no authority to fix urea prices. Then the announcement is meaningless. So I is necessary; it is implicit.
- II is a prediction about what farmers will do after the decision - a future effect, and effects are never assumptions.
- II also carries an extreme, 'will stop' - complete abandonment by every farmer.
- Answer: Only assumption I is implicit.

TRAP

The single biggest killer in this sub-type: mistaking an EFFECT for an assumption. An assumption sits BEHIND the statement, in the past or in the speaker's head. An effect comes AFTER it. 'Prices will rise', 'people will stop', 'the scheme will succeed' - all effects, all wrong.

Assumption, inference, conclusion – three different animals

RPSC mixes these three words across the paper, and students who have not separated them lose marks in both the assumption item and the conclusion item. The difference is simply one of direction in time and logic. An assumption comes before the statement. A conclusion comes out of it. An inference sits in between – it is drawn from the statement, but with a little reasonable reading.

Assumption vs Inference vs Conclusion

	What it is	Test to apply
Assumption	Unstated thing the speaker took for granted BEFORE speaking	Negate it – does the statement collapse?
Inference	Something reasonably read OUT of the statement plus ordinary sense	Is it the most reasonable reading of the data given?
Conclusion	Something that MUST be true given the statement	Can the statement be true and this be false?

Same statement, two different animals

ASSUMPTION (behind it)	CONCLUSION (out of it)
Statement: 'The CM will inaugurate the new expressway on Sunday.'	Statement: 'The CM will inaugurate the new expressway on Sunday.'
Construction of the expressway is complete – taken for granted, else no inauguration.	The expressway is not yet open to the public – it must be true if it is being inaugurated.
Sits in the past / in the speaker's head	Sits in what the words entail
Test by negation	Test by asking 'could this be false?'

Three families of statements have standard, ready-made assumptions. Learn them and you will key these items in ten seconds. Advertisements, notices and instructions, and the 'in spite of' construction.

The three standard assumption families

Statement family	What is automatically implicit
Advertisement	The product has the advertised quality; people want that quality; the ad will influence buyers
Notice, instruction, appeal	The reader can read and understand it; people are likely to comply
Penalty clause in a notice	The prohibited behaviour is expected; the penalty is believed to deter it
'In spite of X, Y happened'	X normally prevents Y
Advisory ('boil the water')	The danger is real; the remedy advised is believed to work

Worked example. Statement: In spite of the heavy rainfall yesterday, the cricket match was completed on schedule. Assumption I: Heavy rainfall never affects the completion of a cricket match. Assumption II: Heavy rainfall usually disrupts the play in a cricket match.

- 'In spite of X, Y happened' presupposes that X normally prevents Y. So rainfall usually disrupts play - II is implicit.
- I says 'never'. But the very use of 'in spite of' shows the speaker thinks rain normally does affect play - I contradicts the statement's own presupposition.
- An extreme word in the item, and a direct clash with the statement: I is out.
- Answer: Only assumption II is implicit.

YAAD RAKHO

Remember - AD, NOTICE, IN SPITE OF. Advertisement: people want the quality. Notice: people will comply. In spite of: the obstacle normally blocks the result. Three families cover roughly half the assumption items ever set.

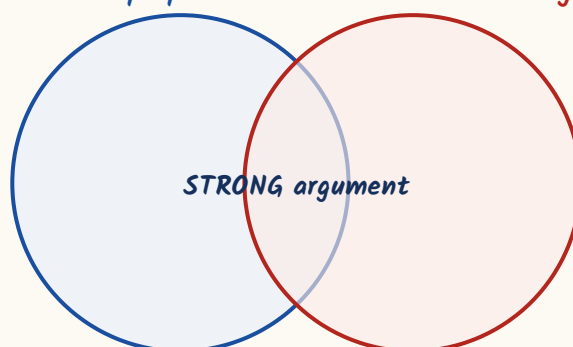
Statement & Argument - what makes an argument strong

Here the statement is a question of policy - 'Should X be done?' - and two arguments follow, usually one Yes and one No. Your job is not to decide the policy. Your job is to judge each argument on two counts. Is it **RELEVANT**, that is, directly related to this very proposal? And is it **SIGNIFICANT**, that is, does it deal with a major aspect rather than a trivial one? Relevance plus significance equals strong. Fail either test and the argument is weak.

What makes an argument strong

Relevant to this proposal

Deals with a weighty aspect



Fail either test and it is weak - saying Yes or No does not decide it.

Strong argument vs weak argument

STRONG	WEAK
Directly about this proposal	Ambiguous, or about something adjacent
Deals with a major, weighty aspect	Deals with a trivial or negligible effect
Rests on an established fact or a serious, foreseeable consequence	Rests on an unverifiable prediction or on emotion
Practical - says what will actually happen if we do this	Restates the proposal in other words (circular)
Offers a real cost or a real gain	Appeals to tradition, to other countries, or to ridicule

- Appeal to tradition - 'we have done it since ancient times' - weak.
- Mere imitation - 'other countries do it' - weak, unless it says WHY it worked there.
- Sweeping generalisation - 'young people are always careless', 'free things are never valued' - weak.
- Personal ridicule or emotion instead of a reason - weak.
- Circular restatement of the proposal - weak, it adds nothing.
- 'It will not solve the problem completely' - weak; a partial remedy can still be justified.
- Yes/No does not decide: a No that gives a real, weighty objection is strong; a Yes with a trivial gain is weak.

Worked example - RAS Pre 2024. Statement: Should private cars be barred from the central business district of big cities during peak hours? Argument I: Yes, it would substantially reduce traffic congestion and air pollution in the most crowded part of the city. Argument II: No, car owners have spent a lot of money on buying their vehicles.

- I is directly about this proposal and names the exact gain it is meant to produce - relevant.
- Congestion and air pollution in the busiest part of a city are major public problems - significant. So I is strong.
- II shifts to the private expenditure of car owners. Money already spent on a car does not weigh against a serious public harm - not significant.
- II is also an appeal to a private interest, not a reasoned objection to the policy - weak.
- Answer: Only argument I is strong.

TRAP

Two weak forms RPSC sets again and again. First: 'No, it will not put an end to every form of cheating / it will not solve the problem fully.' A measure is not useless because it is partial - always weak. Second: 'No, they will come back again' - a defeatist remark that examines nothing. Also weak.

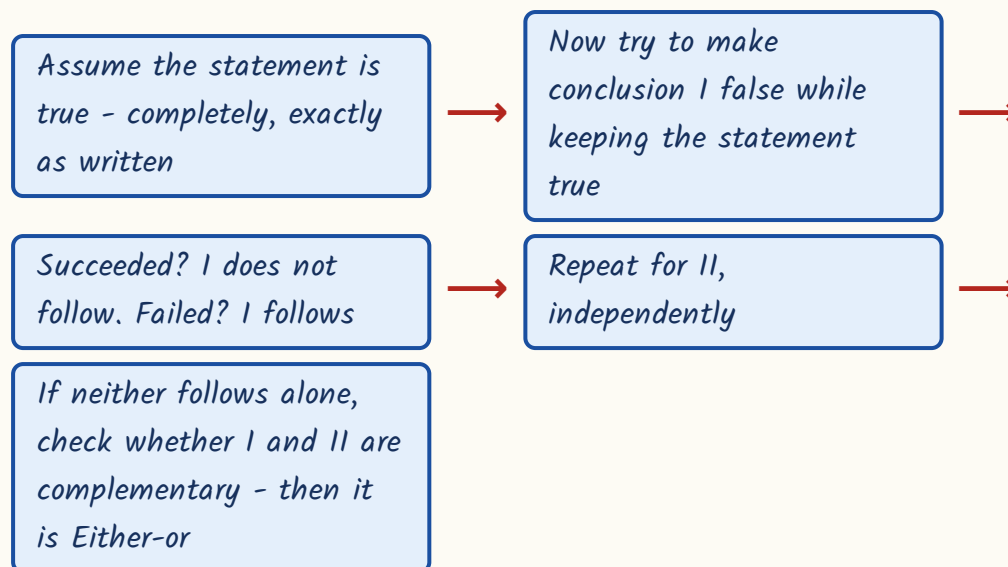
ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2021 - Should all beggars in big cities be sent back to their villages? Yes, it will reduce the population of big cities (trivial effect - weak). No, they will come back again (defeatist, examines neither causes nor rehabilitation - weak). Answer: Neither is strong. The same paper set the LPG-subsidy item where 'the government should never interfere with the market' was weak - a slogan, and self-defeating, since a subsidy is itself an intervention.

Statement & Conclusion - must be true, not likely to be true

A conclusion follows only if it MUST be true given the statement. Not probably true, not sensibly true - necessarily true. There is one test and you should run it mechanically: try to imagine a world where the statement is true and the conclusion is false. If you can build such a world, the conclusion does not follow. If you cannot, it does.

The falsification test



- Percentages never give absolute numbers - a higher rate in A than in B does not prove A has more people.
- 'All P are Q' does not convert to 'All Q are P', and says nothing at all about a non-P.
- A sufficient condition is not a necessary one: 'everyone above 90 got a scholarship' does not mean only they did.
- 'Only those who passed were called' makes passing NECESSARY - so anyone called must have passed.
- Predictions about behaviour ('people will shift to public transport') never follow.
- Neither follows when both conclusions add outside information - causes, motives, comparisons, future behaviour.

Worked example - RAS Pre 2023. Statement: The literacy rate of District A is 78 per cent, while that of District B is 62 per cent. Conclusion I: District A has a larger number of literate persons than District B. Conclusion II: Some persons in District B are illiterate.

- For I, try to falsify. Let A have 1 lakh people - 78,000 literate. Let B have 10 lakh - 6,20,000 literate. Statement true, conclusion false.
- So a rate is not a number. I does not follow.
- For II, B's literacy is 62 per cent, so 38 per cent of B is not literate. Since B has people, some of them are illiterate.
- There is no way to keep the statement true and II false. II follows.
- Answer: Only conclusion II follows.

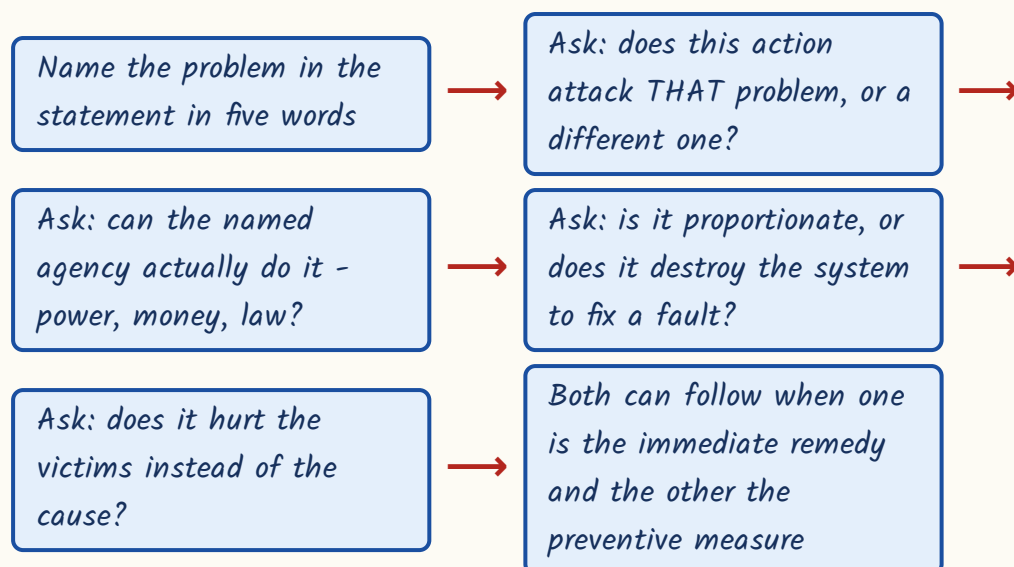
TRAP

Percentage is not population. This is RPSC's favourite conclusion trap and it reappears with literacy, unemployment, pass rates and vaccination coverage. Whenever an option compares NUMBERS and the statement gave you RATES, that option is wrong unless the two totals were also given.

Courses of Action - the twin tests

Here the statement describes a problem and the two items are proposed actions. Run two tests on each. Test one: is the problem real and is it the problem actually stated? Test two: would this action genuinely solve or reduce that problem? An action passes only if the answer to both is yes - and if it is practicable and within the power of the agency named. Two extra filters kill most wrong options: is it proportionate, and does it punish the victim?

Deciding a course of action



Action that follows vs action that does not

FOLLOWS	DOES NOT FOLLOW
Attacks the stated cause directly	Attacks a different problem, or none
Within the authority and means of the agency	Beyond its power or plainly impracticable
Proportionate to the fault	Extreme - ban it, close it down, dismiss everybody
Investigate / fix responsibility / give relief / create awareness through media	Punishes the victim - expel the failing students, stop the mid-day meal
Immediate remedy plus a long-term preventive - both can follow together	A platitude - 'people should be careful'

- The standard strong actions RPSC accepts: order an inquiry, fix responsibility, enforce the existing rule, survey and give relief, add capacity, run awareness through media.
- The standard rejected actions: ban it entirely, close it down, shift the whole population, arrest everyone, silence the complainants.
- Do not choose an action that assumes a problem the statement never mentioned.
- Both follow when I removes the cause and II handles the damage already done - or when I is vector control and II is public awareness.
- Neither follows when both are extreme or both are off-target - this option is real and is set fairly often.

Worked example. Statement: A newly constructed flyover developed wide cracks within six months of being opened to traffic. Course of action I: The flyover should be demolished immediately. Course of action II: A technical inspection should be ordered and responsibility for the substandard work fixed.

- Problem in five words - new flyover cracked early.
- I demolishes before anyone has assessed the damage. Extreme, and premature - it may well be repairable.
- I also destroys public property to answer a fault that has not yet been diagnosed. Not proportionate. I is out.
- II diagnoses the fault through a technical inspection and fixes responsibility for the bad work - the standard, proportionate response, and within the authority's power.
- Answer: Only II follows.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 - candidates caught using unfair means in a recruitment examination. Abolishing recruitment examinations is extreme; debarring the guilty and proceeding under the unfair-means law is the answer - Only II.
RAS Pre 2024 set two: the overturned overcrowded bus (check overloading - Only I; stopping all bus services permanently is disproportionate) and the 'very poor' AQI week (enforce dust and waste-burning curbs - Only II; asking a whole city to leave is impracticable).

The exam-hall drill

These items carry no calculation, so speed comes from having a fixed routine rather than from thinking faster. Thirty to forty seconds each. Read the statement twice and the options once. If an item makes you want to argue about the topic, you have already left the statement - go back to the words.

- Attempt this block early in the paper, while your reading is sharp.
- Never let your verdict on item I colour your verdict on item II - judge them separately.
- Scan the item for an extreme word first; it settles a large share of items in three seconds.
- If you find yourself using a fact from the newspaper, stop - that fact is not in the statement.
- If two rounds of reading leave you undecided, mark and move; do not spend ninety seconds on one mark.

- *Assumption - negate it and see if the statement collapses.*
- *Argument - relevant to this proposal AND about something weighty.*
- *Conclusion - can the statement be true and this false?*
- *Course of action - real problem, and would it actually fix it?*

REVISION RECAP

1. Four sub-types - assumption, argument, conclusion, course of action - and all four appear in every RAS paper, about 4-6 marks together.
2. The one governing rule: the statement is a closed world; never answer from outside knowledge or opinion.
3. Assumption = what the speaker took for granted, unstated but necessary; never something merely true or merely desirable.
4. Negation test for assumptions: suppose it false; if the statement collapses, it is implicit.
5. An effect of the statement is never an assumption behind it - 'farmers will stop using urea' is out.
6. Extreme words in an item - only, all, never, always, every, cannot - kill it, unless the statement is itself that extreme.
7. An item that merely restates the statement is neither an assumption nor a fresh conclusion.
8. Advertisement family: the quality is wanted and the ad will influence buyers. Notice family: people can read it and will comply.
9. 'In spite of X, Y happened' takes for granted that X normally prevents Y.
10. Assumption sits before the statement, conclusion comes out of it, inference is the most reasonable reading of it.
11. Argument test = relevance plus significance; Yes or No has nothing to do with strength.
12. Weak markers: tradition, imitation of other countries, ridicule, sweeping generalisation, circular restatement, 'it will not solve it completely'.
13. Conclusion test: can the statement be true while the conclusion is false? If yes, it does not follow.
14. Rates are not numbers - a higher percentage never proves a larger population of literates, patients or passes.
15. Sufficient is not necessary: 'all above 90 got a scholarship' does not mean nobody else did.

16. 'Only those who passed were called' makes passing necessary - anyone called must have passed.
17. Either I or II follows only when neither holds alone but the two are contradictory and exhaust all possibilities.
18. Course of action twin tests: is the stated problem real, and would this action actually solve it - plus practicable, within authority, proportionate.
19. Reject actions that are extreme, that punish the victim, or that are mere platitudes; accept inquiry, enforcement, relief, capacity and awareness.
20. Both courses follow when one is the immediate remedy and the other the preventive or long-term measure for the same problem.